

Sales Training — Session 30

There Is No Gatekeeper.

Treat Whoever Picks Up as the Perfect Person.

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS How to handle the front-of-business call — the receptionist, the operations manager, the person whose actual title you don't know. The mindset shift that gets reps through more doors, the line that does most of the work, and why the word "gatekeeper" is the first thing to drop from the team's vocabulary.

1. "Gatekeeper" is the first word to drop

The session opened on a single piece of vocabulary that does more damage to the team than any tactic could undo. The word "gatekeeper." It's a melodramatic framing that pre-loads the call with adversarial energy. The person on the other end isn't a medieval guard with a battle-axe. She's a receptionist, or an operations manager, or a partner who happens to answer the phone. None of those people need to be "got past."

Here's the trap. When a rep frames the call as "how do I get past the gatekeeper," the rep enters the call as an outsider trying to breach a wall. That intent leaks into the tone, the pace, the words. The person on the other end senses it instantly — even if they can't name it — and the conversation goes defensive within seconds.

"Gatekeeper is a stupid word. It's too melodramatic. She's not a gatekeeper. She's a receptionist. She's typing emails and probably making coffee for her boss. You rang at the wrong time. That's all that happened."

2. The party analogy — pick your mindset before you dial

The simplest model the session offered. Imagine walking into a party. Two reps arrive at the same door, the same room, the same people. Rep A walks in thinking "this is going to be a pack of difficult people." Rep B walks in thinking "there's at least one person here I'm going to enjoy talking to." Same party. Same people. Two completely different outcomes.

Rep A scans the room confirming their expectation. Each unfriendly face is data for the thesis. The one friendly face goes unnoticed because Rep A isn't looking. Rep B does the opposite — every interaction is a check against "is this my person?" When Rep B finds them, the night is a win. When Rep A leaves without connecting, the night is also a win — they were right.

"Same party. Same people. The difference is one rep goes looking and the other one goes confirming. The cold call is identical. Pick which one you are before you dial."

Carry this into every call. The receptionist who shuts you down isn't a gatekeeper — she's the one person at the party you didn't connect with. The next one might be. The reps who

burn out are the ones who treat every closed door as evidence the whole party is hostile. The reps who last are the ones still scanning the room on call number fifty.

3. Don't pre-judge — you don't actually know who you're talking to

A more concrete reason to drop "gatekeeper." In a 15-person business, the person who answers the phone might be the office manager, the bookkeeper, the owner's partner, or the owner themselves. Reps who treat that voice as an obstacle to clear are routinely talking down to the actual decision-maker without knowing it.

Two illustrative stories from the session. First — a former general manager (Kylie) used to receive sales calls where the rep would dismiss her and ask for "the owner." When Kylie probed and discovered they wanted to sell advertising, she'd reply "actually, I'm the person you need to speak to." By then the rep had already burned the conversation. Second — Corie himself, dressed casually, walked into a luxury car dealership and was treated as a tyre-kicker. He paid cash for the car at a different dealership thirty minutes later. The rep's assumption cost the salesperson the commission.

The discipline: stop labelling the voice on the other end. The cleaner might be the owner's best friend with a referral relationship. The receptionist might be the office manager who makes the buying decision. The person who sounds disinterested might be the buyer testing whether you'll respect them. You don't know. So don't pre-judge.

"The best person to speak to in business development is the person who's actually on the phone with you. Even who's the cleaner. You don't know what their relationship is."

4. "You're the perfect person to speak to" — the line that does the work

The single line the session built the whole call structure around. When the rep gets through to anyone, the opener is some variation of: "I think you're actually the perfect person to speak to about this." The line has the property of being useful in both possible outcomes.

Outcome one — they actually are the right person. They feel respected, the rep has skipped the offensive opening ("is the owner there?"), and the conversation starts on solid ground. Outcome two — they're not the right person. People love to correct. They will tell the rep "actually, you need to speak to Bob in sales," and they'll hand over the name and often the email. The rep is now armed with an internal reference: "Hi Bob, Sandra at reception suggested I get in touch."

"You're the perfect person to speak to. Either it's true and you've got the buyer, or it isn't and they'll correct you — and you've got the buyer's name from someone inside the business. Asymmetric upside. No real downside."

Note the structure. The rep doesn't ask "who's the right person?" — that's the offensive version, because it implies the person on the phone isn't important. The rep declares the person on the phone IS the right person. If they aren't, the correction comes for free, with dignity intact on both sides.

5. Be correctable — exploit the desire to be right

A general principle hiding inside the "perfect person" move. Humans love being right. Correcting someone is a small but real pleasure. A good rep weaponises this — gently — by making small, easily-correctable statements that pull information out of the buyer without ever having asked a question.

Examples from the session:

- "This looks like a really light campaign — you must be paying around \$100 to \$200, would I be right?" (Session 29). The buyer corrects: "Actually it's \$700." The rep now has the price.
- "You're the perfect person to speak to." The receptionist corrects: "Actually, you need Bob." The rep now has the buyer's name.
- "I think you must be the operations manager?" — half-statement, half-question. They correct, the rep learns their role without asking.

Be correctable on small, low-stakes claims. Never be correctable on the buyer's pain or the product's value — those are where the rep has to be right. Use correctability to extract context the buyer wouldn't volunteer if asked outright.

6. "Have you heard of us?" — open a gap, dismantle the script

A specific verbal move worth memorising. Early in the call, after introducing the agency, the rep asks: "Have you heard of Marketing Sweet before?" The question is doing several jobs at once.

First, it implies the agency is well-known enough that the receptionist should have. That shifts the cognitive footing — instead of the rep proving credibility, the buyer is briefly worried about whether they should have heard of you. Second, it interrupts the script the buyer was running. Their brain was preparing the "not interested" autopilot — now it's diverted into trying to remember whether the name rings a bell. That diversion opens a few seconds of genuine attention.

Third, the answer is almost never embarrassing for either party. "Yeah, I think so" is the most common response, which moves the conversation forward. "No" gives the rep an easy follow-up: "All good, here's the very short version..." Either way, the rep has bought 10 seconds of fresh attention from a buyer who was on the verge of hanging up.

7. Stage 1, 2, 3 responses — think before you speak

The session called out a common rep weakness: blurting out the first thing that comes to mind, rather than thinking through what the buyer is hearing. Corie labels these as "stage one" responses — surface-level reactions to the literal words. Stage two is the buyer's internal reaction. Stage three is what the rep should say given what stage two is going to be.

Worked example from the session. Rep says: "Hi Sandra, it's Phil here from Marketing Sweet, how are you?" Stage one (rep): a polite greeting. Stage two (buyer's head): "He wants to sell me something. I've got 10,000 things to do." Stage three (what the rep should say given stage two): something that breaks the script in the first sentence. "I've got some really interesting findings about your website — I think you're the perfect person to send them to."

The discipline: pause before each line and run it through stage two. "What is the receptionist actually hearing right now?" If the answer is "another sales pitch I need to escape from," change the line. If the answer is "this person sounds like they know what they're talking about," you're on track.

"Don't get into your own head. Get into theirs. Then say what makes sense to the person already there."

8. Follow the process — even when your gut says it's a dead deal

The session returned to a discipline that's appeared across multiple training sessions, and underlined it again. The rep's gut instinct about which calls will convert is wildly unreliable. The buyer who sounds enthusiastic and complimentary often doesn't buy — they're being polite to soften the rejection. The buyer who's flat, terse, and price-focused often does — they're negotiating, which means they intend to spend.

This means the rep's job is to run the standard process every time, regardless of how the call feels mid-flight. Don't skip the trial close because you've decided they're a tyre-kicker. Don't push extra value on the buyer who already sounds sold. The process exists to remove the rep's emotion from the decision — and the emotion is usually wrong.

"Don't follow your thoughts. Follow your process. The only time you break the process is when the client themselves tells you to — when they say 'just send me the contract' — then break the process and close them."

The corollary: when the process is followed properly and the rep is convinced the deal is dead, ask anyway. "Would you like to go to the next step?" — said in the same tone you've used the whole call. Reps who do this consistently report being shocked by how often the answer is "yes" from a buyer they'd written off internally.

9. The trial close — get within striking distance

A specific technique used near the end of a meeting or call, before the rep asks for the deal. The trial close is a small, low-stakes question used to test how close the rep is to the kill — "is there anything I haven't covered?" "Is there anything you're still unsure about?" "Have I forgotten anything?"

The trial close serves two purposes. First, it surfaces unspoken objections — buyers often have a concern they haven't said out loud, and the trial close gives them permission to raise it. Second, it tells the rep whether they're within striking distance of the deal. If the buyer responds with "no, I think you've covered everything," the rep is close — that's the moment to ask for the sale. If the buyer responds with new questions or hesitations, the rep knows there's still ground to cover before asking.

"I want to get within shocking distance of the sale. I don't want to go in for the kill when I'm miles away — that's gambling. The trial close tells me whether I'm in range."

10. Treat the receptionist as the boss's partner

A practical version of the no-pre-judging rule. The session offered an analogy: when you visit a friend's house and they have a partner, you don't ignore the partner. If you do, you don't get invited back. The receptionist has the same role in the office that the partner has at home — they're the person the decision-maker actually consults when no-one's watching.

If a rep gets past a dismissed receptionist and pitches the owner well, the owner often says "let me come back to you" — and then asks the receptionist what she thought. If the rep was rude or dismissive on the way through, the receptionist will quietly torpedo the deal. The rep blames the price, the timing, the product. The real cause was a 30-second exchange three weeks earlier.

"If you treat her like she's in your way, you might get past her. But when the boss is floating around the office, who does he actually talk to? She's the boss's partner. That's how you need to treat her."

11. The one rule under all the others: don't say dumb things

If the entire session collapsed to one sentence, it would be this. The rep cannot control how many calls convert. They cannot control how many buyers happen to be ready that day. They cannot control whether a receptionist is in a good mood. What the rep CAN control is whether they say something that makes the call worse than it had to be.

Dumb things include: calling someone a gatekeeper to their face, pigeonholing them by role, asking for "the decision maker" in the first 30 seconds, talking over the receptionist to demand the owner, pitching aggressively before establishing context, blurting stage-one responses without thinking through stage two, and pre-judging the buyer's potential based on how they sound in the first sentence.

"There's a lot of things you can do to make the call better. There's even more things you can do to make it worse. Just don't say dumb things — that's most of the job."

12. Hard now, easy later — Charlie Munger's punch card

A final mental model to carry into every shift. Charlie Munger's famous suggestion: imagine you have a punch card with 20 holes — one for each major decision in your life. Each call, each line, each judgment is a punch. Use them deliberately. Don't waste them on emotional reactions or shortcuts that feel good in the moment but burn the long-term opportunity.

Applied to sales: the receptionist call you take in five minutes will be one of 10,000 you'll make. The hole you punch isn't the one that gets through to the buyer today. The hole you punch is the choice between being the rep who treats receptionists with respect (and gets a 10% lift across a career) and the rep who treats them as obstacles (and burns the same opportunities over and over).

That 10% lift isn't visible call-to-call. It's felt over the year. The reps who lasted in Corie's organisations weren't the ones who closed every deal — they were the ones who could be kind on call 47 of the day with the same warmth as call 1. That's the punch worth making.

"All you need to do is punch out a few good holes in your entire career. This is one of those moments where I'm asking you to punch the right hole — be kind. The cumulative 10% on top of that lasts the rest of your life."

13. Action items for the team

1. Remove the word "gatekeeper" from internal vocabulary. Replace with "receptionist" or "front desk." Words shape the call.
2. Replace "is the owner there?" with "I think you might be the perfect person to speak to about this." Use it on every call this week.
3. Add "Have you heard of Marketing Sweet before?" to the opening sequence — within the first 20 seconds of a new call.
4. Before any line, pause and ask: "what is the person on the other end actually hearing right now?" If the answer is "another sales pitch," change the line.
5. End every meeting with a trial close before asking for the deal: "Is there anything I haven't covered?" Then — and only then — ask for the next step.
6. Ask for the deal even when you're convinced the buyer won't go ahead. Treat that gut instinct as unreliable.
7. On the next 10 calls, count how many times you said something you could've left out. Reduce the count each week.

THE RULE OF THUMB There is no gatekeeper. There's a person picking up the phone, and they're the perfect person to speak to. Either they'll prove you right or they'll correct you — both outcomes get you closer to the deal.